A vibrant democracy, a strong economy and a powerful military machine are the symbols of our nation's strength. The manifestation of this strength would come about with the indomitable will of our people, and the insurmountable resolve of its soldiers.[1] No nation can achieve greatness without overcoming challenges, and India is no exception. An analysis of India's national security has to take cognizance of both external and internal challenges to its national unity and territorial integrity. Quite often, internal threats can erode the cohesiveness of a nation more critically than any external danger. Though the last major conflict we had was the 1971 Indo–Pak war, the past four decades have been an era of 'no peace no war'. We have had the Kargil conflict in 1999 and two major stand-offs: the first in 1987 as a result of Exercise Brass Tacks, and the second, known as Operation Parakram, from December 2001 to October 2002, consequent to the Pakistan-sponsored terrorist attack on our Parliament. All three could have triggered an all-out war between India and Pakistan. Accordingly, national power based on political stability, social cohesion, military strength and economic progress would remain central to the future of India's national security. Therefore, India seeks to improve its relations with its neighbours and have a peaceful security environment so that it can concentrate on economic and technological development and inclusive growth of its people.

Unfortunately, India is situated in a turbulent and unstable region with the presence of failing or unstable states, declining regional powers, and states that have facilitated nuclear proliferation. The region has emerged as the epicentre of global terrorism and has the maximum number of countries possessing weapons of mass destruction, with the increasing risk of non-state actors laying their hands on such deadly weapons. Over and above these, we have unresolved boundary issues with China and Pakistan. There are not many countries in the world that have to face the full spectrum of threats as India does, from low intensity to an all-out conventional war in diverse terrain while keeping in mind the nuclear overhang. To deal with them we would require an array of defensive and offensive capabilities, so as to deter or blunt the aggressive designs